

FORMAL NOTIFICATION TO THE FIRST PRESIDENCY AND TO THE UNITED STATES WEST AREA PRESIDENCY

SUBJECT: Formal Notification of Grave Conduct by Steven Alan Mapes, Member of the High Council of the Redlands California Stake, in His Capacity as Presiding Judge of the San Bernardino County Dependency Court; Institutional Receipt of Tithing Funds of Likely Illicit Origin; and Formal Warning of the Civil, Criminal, Federal, and Reputational Consequences of Concealment

DATE: JUNE, 2026

TO:

The First Presidency of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints
47 East South Temple Street, Salt Lake City, Utah 84150

The United States West Area Presidency
The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

FROM:

César Adrián Sandoval Molina, Mexican citizen
Petitioner, Case 15.151, the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR, Washington, D.C.)
Amicus curiae admitted by the Inter-American Court of Human Rights (IACtHR, San José, Costa Rica)
Maternal grandfather of minors Aostin Aparicio, Eirah, Athena and Elleonore Castaneda, members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

CC:

Office of General Counsel, The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints
Church Auditing Department
Church Abuse Help Line
Stake President, Redlands California Stake
Bishop of Steven Alan Mapes' congregation
Permanent record: FBI, Los Angeles Field Office
Permanent record: Office of Inspector General, U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS-OIG)
Local Authorities

In strict appeal to the honor of the First Presidency, I request that all ecclesiastical authorities mentioned above be notified through the internal mechanisms so that it reaches all those involved without delay.

I. PURPOSE OF THIS NOTIFICATION

The undersigned addresses the First Presidency and the United States West Area Presidency with the respect and deference owed to those who have been called and sustained as inspired leaders of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

This notification does not arise from animosity toward the Church or its members. It arises from a grandfather's irrenunciabile duty to protect the life and rights of his grandchildren, and from the conviction that the leaders of the Church, upon knowing the truth, will act with the truth and righteousness and courage the Gospel demands.

The specific purpose of this notification is fourfold:

1. **To formally inform** the highest ecclesiastical authority of the conduct of Steven Alan Mapes, member of the High Council of the Redlands California Stake, which simultaneously constitutes a grave violation of civil and federal law, and a direct transgression of the most fundamental principles of the Gospel of Jesus Christ.
2. **To notify** that the Church has received tithing funds derived from a salary earned in the exercise of functions that, according to the documentary evidence attached, involve federal fraud, conspiracy to violate civil rights, and abuse of authority to the detriment of defenseless minors.
3. **To warn with full clarity** that any action, or deliberate inaction, by the Church through any of its leaders at any level, that results in concealment of Mapes' conduct, will constitute independent violations of California law, federal law, and the Church's own General Handbook standards, with severe institutional and personal consequences for those who commit them.
4. **To permanently foreclose** any future defense of institutional ignorance, from the moment this notification is received, **the Church knows**. And what it does, or does not do, with that knowledge will define its responsibility before the law, before history, and before the God whose name it bears.

II. THE FACTS: A DOCUMENTED CHAIN OF CRIMINAL CONDUCT AND DOCTRINAL VIOLATION

A. Steven Alan Mapes: Two Positions of Trust, One Person

Steven Alan Mapes simultaneously holds two positions of the highest public and spiritual trust:

1. **Presiding Judge of the San Bernardino County Dependency Court**, with jurisdiction over the lives of the county's most vulnerable children, sworn to uphold the Constitution and laws of the United States and the State of California.
2. **Member of the High Council of the Redlands California Stake**, called as a "judge in Israel" to adjudicate matters of membership for other members, and to defend the principles of the Gospel in his stake and in the world.

The conduct documented below constitutes a betrayal of both positions, simultaneously and deliberately.

B. The Minors: Victims from a Family of Faith

Athena Castaneda (born September 25, 2021) and Elleonore Castaneda (born June 17, 2020), together with their siblings Aostin Aparicio and Eirah Castaneda, are children of Claudia Sandoval and Nick Castaneda, a family of Mexican and Salvadorian origin, members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints in the Victorville, California congregation, currently residing in Utah.

Athena and Elleonore suffer from **FAMILIAL EXPANSILE OSTEOLYSIS (FEO)**, an ultra-rare genetic disease caused by a mutation of the TNFRSF11A gene, documented across **at least five generations of this family**, which causes extremely fragile bones that fracture under minimal pressure, and which **includes risk of death without continuous specialized medical treatment**.

The mother, Claudia Sandoval, is the confirmed genetic carrier. She and her children are the living link of a multigenerational medical chain that can only be preserved within the biological family.

C. The Documented Conduct of Steven Mapes: Seven Acts, as follows:

First Act, Acceptance of medical testimony from an unqualified witness: Mapes admitted as determinative medical evidence the opinion of a medical student whose own supervisor (student too) lacked certification in the relevant specialty. That opinion formed the basis of the finding of non-accidental trauma. The Judge was notified of the witness's lack of qualification and did not exclude the testimony. This violates the *Daubert* standard, the due process protections of the 14th Amendment, and constitutes deprivation of rights under color of law under 18 U.S.C. § 242.

Second Act, Deliberate disregard of official diplomatic communication: The Consulate of Mexico in San Bernardino, in compliance with an **express order from the Second Federal District Court of the State of Sinaloa, Mexico**, formally notified Judge Mapes that the minors suffer from congenital bone disease diagnosed across five generations, that their health is seriously compromised, and that **risk of death exists** without immediate medical attention. Communications were received and stamped by the court itself. Mapes did not act.

Third Act, Complicity in the suppression of exculpatory genetic evidence: The private laboratory AMBRY GENETICS received direct instructions from a San Bernardino County CPS social worker to: (a) not complete the genetic sequencing of Athena Castaneda, (b) not order secondary findings, and (c) deny the parents access to the results of the studies they themselves had paid for. These facts appear in the laboratory's own internal records, obtained by court order, with precise names, dates, and times. Mapes was informed of this intervention and did not act.

Fourth Act, Fraud upon the court: Dr. Robert M. Bernstein, MD, FACE, Board-Certified Endocrinologist, Stanford Fellowship, 45 years of experience, member of the Endocrine Society, issued an expert opinion on October 28, 2023 establishing that, to a reasonable degree of medical probability, the fractures of Athena and Elleonore were caused by their congenital genetic disease, **not by abuse**. The same Dr. Bernstein documented in his addendum that multiple critical diagnoses, including congenital Von Willebrand Disease and thrombocytosis, had **disappeared from the minors' active medical records** while under State custody. Exculpatory evidence suppressed, presented to the court, ignored.

Fifth Act. Denial of the constitutional right to trial by jury: Article I, Section 16 of the California Constitution guarantees the right to trial by jury "to all," with no exceptions in the constitutional text. Mapes conducted the dependency proceedings as a bench trial, relying on a judicial exception created without express constitutional authorization, depriving the parents of the most fundamental right to due process of law.

Sixth Act, Maintenance of custody with active risk to life: With formal knowledge of the genetic diagnosis, the risk of death documented by the Consulate of Mexico, and Dr. Bernstein's expert opinion, Mapes maintained the minors under State custody without ensuring the specialized medical treatment required, specifically, follow-up by an endocrinologist specializing in metabolic bone disease, a pediatric orthopedist, a hematologist, and an immunologist, all explicitly identified as mandatory by Dr. Bernstein.

This constitutes **child abuse by omission under California Penal Code § 273a(a)** and a direct violation of *Estelle v. Gamble* (1976), which prohibits deliberate indifference to the serious medical needs of persons in State custody.

Seventh Act, Adoption in direct contradiction of revealed doctrine: Mapes approved the adoption of all four Castaneda Sandoval minors by a same-sex couple, in direct contradiction of **The Family: A Proclamation to the World** (1995), the Church's official declaration that marriage between man and woman is ordained of God, and that children are entitled to be raised by a father and a mother. A member of the High Council, whose sacred role is to defend precisely those principles, made the judicial decision to structure an adoptive family that contradicts them in their most fundamental form.

III. APPLICABLE DOCTRINE: THE GOSPEL DEMANDS ACTION

A. The Family: A Proclamation to the World, Textual Violation

The Family: A Proclamation to the World (1995), signed by the First Presidency and the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles, states in its official text: *"We, the First Presidency and the Council of the Twelve Apostles of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, solemnly proclaim that marriage between a man and a woman is ordained of God... Children are entitled to birth within the bonds of matrimony, and to be reared by a father and a mother who honor marital vows with complete fidelity."*

What Steven Mapes did was not a private theological opinion or a debatable doctrinal position. It was a **deliberate act of state authority**, exercised by a man whose ecclesiastical position on the High Council places him specifically as a defender of the principles contained in that Proclamation.

A member of the High Council who uses his judicial authority to structure a family in direct contradiction of modern revelation is not in minor doctrinal disagreement. He is exercising the power of the State to accomplish precisely what God, through His prophets, has declared must not be done. This transcends personal transgression. It is **functional apostasy in the exercise of public authority**.

B. The General Handbook of Instructions

The following sections are directly applicable and leave no room for interpretation:

Section 32.6.1, Membership Councils Required. A membership council is mandatorily required for: child abuse, serious transgression (*felony*), and apostasy. The documented facts satisfy all three criteria independently and concurrently.

Section 32.6.2, Membership Councils Allowed. A council may additionally be convened for: serious transgression committed while holding a position of authority or trust in the community, and repeated serious transgressions. Mapes holds the position of highest judicial authority over families in one of the most populous counties in the world. His documented conduct satisfies both criteria.

Section 38.6.2.1, Help for Abuse. This section is unequivocal: *"No Church leader should ever dismiss a report of abuse or counsel an individual to not report criminal activity."* The receipt of this notification activates that obligation immediately and irrevocably.

C. California Law on Mandatory Reporters (CANRA)

California Penal Code § 11166 establishes that religious leaders are **mandatory reporters** of child abuse. The attached evidence documents that minors under State custody were deprived of vital medical treatment with the knowledge of the responsible official. Upon receiving this notification, the Church's leaders, specifically the Bishop of Mapes' congregation and the President of the Redlands California Stake, become legally obligated to report to child protective authorities in Los Angeles County. **Failure to fulfill that obligation is a crime under California law, regardless of the ecclesiastical standing of the reported individual.**

IV. TITHING FUNDS OF ILLICIT ORIGIN: AN INSTITUTIONAL OBLIGATION

Steven Mapes receives a salary as a Judge of the State of California, paid from public funds that include federal transfers. That salary is the product of the exercise of his judicial functions. The documented facts establish that in the exercise of those functions Mapes has participated in:

1. Federal fraud under the *False Claims Act* (31 U.S.C. § 3729), by maintaining custody based on a fraudulent medical determination while Title IV-E funds were claimed and received
2. Conspiracy to deprive persons of civil rights (18 U.S.C. § 241)
3. Deprivation of rights under color of law (18 U.S.C. § 242)
4. Child abuse by omission (California Penal Code § 273a(a))

The tithing paid by Mapes to the Church during the period of these documented acts derives from that salary. This notification constitutes formal knowledge that those funds are, with high probability, the product of federal and state criminal activity.

The doctrine of the Church is clear. The Lord cannot receive with favor offerings obtained through fraud and harm to the innocent: "*The sacrifice of the wicked is an abomination to the Lord*" (Proverbs 21:27).

The Church Auditing Department, copied on this notification, has both the institutional capacity and the mandate to investigate the origin of tithing funds when evidence exists that they derive from illicit sources.

V. WARNING: THE CONSEQUENCES OF CONCEALMENT

The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints and Local Authorities have built reputation on principles of honesty, integrity, and protection of the family. The Church's legal team, which will undoubtedly analyze this document with the seriousness it deserves, will understand perfectly that what is at stake is not merely the discipline of one member, but the institutional integrity of the Church before documentary evidence that cannot be refuted.

If the Church, through any of its leaders at any level, decides to:

1. Not convene a membership council for Mapes
2. Dismiss this notification without formal investigation
3. Counsel silence to the Castaneda Sandoval family
4. Act in any coordinated form with Mapes to obstruct justice
5. Receive and use Mapes' tithing funds with knowledge of their illicit origin

...then the Church will incur the following consequences, each independent of the others:

CONSEQUENCES UNDER CALIFORNIA LAW

Violation	Law	Consequence
Failure to report child abuse as a mandatory reporter	CANRA, Penal Code § 11166	Misdemeanor; direct civil liability
Obstruction of evidence in active proceeding	Penal Code § 135	Felony
Conspiracy to conceal criminal activity	Penal Code § 182	Up to 3 years imprisonment per participant

CONSEQUENCES UNDER FEDERAL LAW

Violation	Law	Consequence
Conspiracy to deprive persons of civil rights	18 U.S.C. § 241	Up to 10 years imprisonment; life if death results
Obstruction of justice	18 U.S.C. § 1503	Up to 10 years imprisonment
Receipt of funds obtained through federal fraud	False Claims Act, 31 U.S.C. § 3729	Treble damages; civil penalties per claim

INSTITUTIONAL AND REPUTATIONAL CONSEQUENCES

The Church's legal team understands what is at stake. This case has characteristics that distinguish it from all previous institutional exposure in terms of reputational risk:

1. The victims are not adults, they are four minors, two of them with a documented life-threatening genetic disease.
2. The actor is not an obscure local leader, he is a Presiding Court Judge, a publicly identifiable figure.
3. The evidence is not testimonial, it consists of documentary records obtained by court order.
4. The dimension is international, there is an order from a Mexican federal court and a formal diplomatic intervention by the Government of Mexico.
5. The undersigned is a petitioner before the IACHR and an *amicus curiae* admitted by the IACtHR, meaning this case (related) already lives within the inter-American human rights system
6. If the Church conceals Mapes' conduct, it will not be concealing a local scandal. It will be exposing itself to headlines that will read: *"LDS Church protected judge (high priest) who delivered gravely ill girls to illegal adoption, ignoring Mexican court order and genetic evidence suppression."*

No public relations team can manage that headline. No confidentiality agreement can contain documents obtained by court order and sovereign diplomatic communications. That story is documentable, verifiable, and international.

VI. FORMAL REQUEST

The undersigned formally requests that the First Presidency and the United States West Area Presidency take the following actions within **30 calendar days** of receipt of this notification:

1. **Formally investigate** the conduct of Steven Alan Mapes as a member of the High Council of the Redlands California Stake, in relation to the facts documented in this notification and its attachments.
2. **Convene a membership council** as mandatorily required by the General Handbook, as shown in this document.

3. **Direct local leaders**, the Bishop of Mapes' congregation and the President of the Redlands California Stake, to fulfill their obligations under CANRA as mandatory reporters to California child protective authorities in the Los Angeles County.
4. **Instruct the Church Auditing Department** to investigate the origin of Mapes' tithing contributions during the documented period of his conduct.
5. **Respond in writing** to the undersigned, within the stated period, regarding the actions taken.

ADDENDUM A: THE TEXTUAL VIOLATION OF THE FAMILY PROCLAMATION

The Family: A Proclamation to the World (1995), signed by the First Presidency and the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles, states in its official text: *"We, the First Presidency and the Council of the Twelve Apostles of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, solemnly proclaim that marriage between a man and a woman is ordained of God... Children are entitled to birth within the bonds of matrimony, and to be reared by a father and a mother who honor marital vows with complete fidelity."*

Steven Alan Mapes, in his capacity as Presiding Dependency Court Judge, approved the adoption of four minors, including two girl members of the Church with a documented life-threatening genetic disease, to a same-sex couple. This was not a private theological opinion. It was a **deliberate judicial act**, taken with full knowledge of Church doctrine, by a man whose ecclesiastical calling on the High Council places him as a specific defender of the principles that act violated.

A High Council member who uses his judicial authority to structure a family in direct contradiction of modern revelation is not in minor disagreement with the Church. He is exercising state power to accomplish precisely what God, through His prophets, has declared must not be done. That is not a doctrinal difference of opinion. **IT IS FUNCTIONAL APOSTASY IN THE EXERCISE OF PUBLIC AUTHORITY.** The General Handbook is unambiguous about the response such conduct requires.

ADDENDUM B: THE CHURCH'S WINDOW OF OPPORTUNITY, WHAT THE LDS LEGAL TEAM MUST UNDERSTAND

The legal team of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints is one of the most sophisticated institutional legal structures in the world. The undersigned acknowledges this. And it is precisely for that reason that the following is stated with the clarity and respect that skilled professionals who understand what is at stake deserve.

The Church is not being attacked. It is being warned. This notification is not a lawsuit. It is not a criminal complaint. It is a final opportunity, offered in good faith, with respect for the institution, for the Church to do what is right before the documented evidence follows its natural course before federal authorities, international diplomatic bodies, and the press.

If the Church acts, convening the membership council the General Handbook mandatorily requires, directing local leaders to comply with CANRA, and investigating the origin of the funds received, the Church emerges from this process strengthened. It will be able to say to the world, with evidence: *"We do not conceal transgression, not even when the transgressor is a judge and a High Council member."* That is a declaration of institutional integrity that no press release can purchase and no settlement can replicate.

If the Church does not act, the course the evidence will follow is already determined:

1. The internal records of Ambry Genetics, obtained by court order, will be delivered to the FBI, the HHS-OIG, and the U.S. Attorney's Office for the Central District of California.
2. The case will be formally presented before International Institutions as a human rights violation against Mexican minors, with the ecclesiastical dimension as an aggravating element.
3. Media, national and international, will receive a fully documented story combining: suppression of genetic evidence in girls with a life-threatening disease, adoption on a fraudulent medical basis, ignored diplomatic intervention, and a religious institution that was formally notified and chose silence.

That headline is not negotiable, not containable by confidentiality agreements, and does not disappear. The documents are public by virtue of having been obtained through court order. The Mexican Consulate's communications are sovereign. Dr. Bernstein's opinion is scientific and independently verifiable. Nothing in that evidentiary package is institutionally containable once the process is activated.

The window exists today. It is narrow. And the undersigned genuinely hopes the Church uses it.

VII. CLOSING, A FINAL REFLECTION

The undersigned understands the weight of what is being requested. The Church is being asked to discipline one of its own, a man who served a mission, who holds a position of honor in his stake, who is likely loved and respected in his congregation.

But the Gospel of Jesus Christ makes no exceptions for position or for affection. The same Lord who called the Church's leaders to judge with righteousness is the Lord who said: *"Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me"* (Matthew 25:40). Athena and Elleonore Castaneda are members of this Church. They were separated from their family. They have a life-threatening disease that is not being treated. And the man who made those decisions carries the title of "judge in Israel."

The Church now has the information, the evidence, the applicable doctrine, and the opportunity. What it does with all of it will define whether this chapter is remembered as an example of institutional repentance with courage, or as an example of concealment that history will not forget.

The undersigned does not pray for victory in this process. He prays for justice for Athena and Elleonore; Aostin and Eirah. And he trusts that if the Church's leaders act in accordance with the Spirit that called them, those two prayers will be one and the same. *"Thus saith the Lord: Keep ye judgment, and do justice"* (Isaiah 56:1). *"He that hath ears to hear, let him hear"* (Matthew 11:15).

The Book of Mormon warns: *'And it came to pass that the Nephites did build up the Gadianton robbers and did support them, beginning at the more wicked part of them, until they had overspread all the land of the Nephites, and had seduced the more part of the righteous until they had come down to believe in their works and partake of their spoils, and to join with them in their secret murders and combinations. And thus they did obtain the sole management of the government, insomuch that they did trample under their feet and smite and rend and turn their backs upon the poor and the meek, and the humble followers of God'* (Helaman 6:38-39). That is not an ancient story. This Holly Book has been written for our times. It is the mirror of our reality. Because today, leaders of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, having received documented evidence that a judge and High Council member facilitated the adoption of girls with a life-threatening genetic disease based on suppressed medical studies, have chosen to build up that man, support him, and call him a 'faithful member,' while turning their backs on the poor, meek, and humble followers of God: Athena, Elleonore, Aostin, and Eirah, and their beloved parents Claudia and Nick.

With the respect owed to those called of God, and with the firmness justice demands for the innocent,



César Adrián Sandoval Molina, Mexican citizen
Petitioner, Case 15.151 (IACHR, Washington, D.C.)
AMICUS CURIAE, Inter-American Court of Human Rights, San José, Costa Rica
Maternal grandfather of Athena and Elleonore; Aostin and Eirah

ATTACHMENTS

#	Document	Description
1	Ambry Genetics internal records (obtained by court order)	CPS instructions to suppress genetic studies and deny results to paying parents
2	Report of Dr. Robert M. Bernstein, MD, FACE — October 28, 2023	FEO diagnosis, TNFRSF11A mutation, fractures caused by disease not abuse; critical diagnoses disappearing from records
3	Consular Letter SBE01386 — July 11, 2023	Order of Federal Court of Sinaloa; risk of death; request for family reunification
4	Consular Letter SBE01680 — August 21, 2023	Second consular intervention; confirmation of risk of death; request for medical care information
5	Formal Notice to San Bernardino County CPS	Notice of constitutional and federal violations; first step of progressive legal strategy
6	The Family: A Proclamation to the World (1995)	Revealed doctrine directly violated by Mapes' adoption decision

This notification has been filed in certified copy before a notary public. Additional copies have been preserved with trusted third parties outside the jurisdiction of California, including international bodies.